

WHAT ARE WE?

For the woman doing girlfriend work without the title. How to ask once, hear the truth, and stop paying for a maybe.

The Connection Code

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Before You Start

This is a short book with one job. It gets you an answer to a question you've been postponing, and it deals with the money sitting underneath it.

It isn't a book about making him commit. That book exists, several versions of it, and it doesn't work. What you'll get here is clarity, which is a different thing and a more useful one.

If you're hoping for a method that produces a yes, this will disappoint you. If you'd rather know, keep reading.

ABOUT THE PEOPLE IN THIS BOOK

The people in this book are composite examples, drawn from experiences women and men commonly describe about the talking stage. Their names, ages and details are illustrative, not real people. Some of them are men, and some of the most honest answers about why a talking stage stalls come from them.

INTRODUCTION: Girlfriend Work

You do the things a girlfriend does.

You check whether he's eaten. You know his work schedule and his sister's name. You've met two of his friends. You've cancelled plans for him. When he's low you're the one who notices first.

You just don't have the title. And because you don't have the title, you can't ask for anything that comes with it, which means you're doing the work and carrying none of the standing.

That's what this book calls girlfriend work, and once you've got a name for it you'll see it everywhere.

What you'll find on the internet about this

Plenty, and some of it is good.

There's plenty written about the talking stage, and some of it is good, especially the guides on leaving one without ghosting. Read them. This book isn't going to pretend they don't exist.

Here's what none of it covers.

Money has changed hands. Probably in both directions. Nobody has ever said what it was for, and neither of you would be able to say cleanly whether it was generosity, courtship, or an investment somebody expects a return on.

That's the part you can't google, and it's the reason "just walk away" costs you more than the people giving that advice realise.

The money nobody mentions

Ask a group of people what a first date should cost and the answers can be ten times apart. One names the price of a simple lunch. Another names something close to a month's rent.

Sit with that against what most people actually earn.

Akosua, 22, would be happy with lunch. Ife, 30, expects dinner somewhere nice. Kofi, 32, thinks it has all got out of hand: "There's nothing romantic about spending your rent money on dinner."

That's the first date. You've been in this for months. Maybe years.

So there is a number between you. You've never calculated it, he probably hasn't either, and both of you are behaving as though it doesn't exist while it quietly shapes every conversation you're too nervous to start.

THE ARGUMENT OF THIS BOOK

The reason you cannot ask "what are we" is not that you lack courage. It is that you sense there is an invoice somewhere in the room, you do not know what is on it, and you are afraid of what asking might trigger. Deal with the money and the question gets easy.

What this book will not do

It won't make him commit. Nothing does, and material promising otherwise is teaching you to manipulate someone you claim to love.

It won't tell you what he's thinking. You'll ask him. That's the whole method.

It won't tell you a clear no is a tragedy. Chapter 7 makes the opposite case.

How to read it

Seven short chapters. Chapters 1 and 2 explain why you're stuck. Chapter 3 gives you two numbers and is the most uncomfortable forty minutes in the book.

Chapter 4 is the question itself. Seven scripts across the book, in two registers, written to be sent without editing.

Chapters 5 and 6 are the ones nobody else has written. What to do when he gives you a non-answer, and what to do when the money he spent gets presented to you as a debt.

Start with what you've been calling a stage.

CHAPTER 1: It Stopped Being a Stage

A stage is something you pass through.

School has stages. Pregnancy has stages. The word carries a promise that there's a next one, and that's why it's such a comfortable word to use about a situation that isn't moving. Calling it a stage means you're on the way somewhere.

Wanjiru was 27. She was in hers for almost three years.

Three years isn't a stage. It's an arrangement, and arrangements have terms, and the terms of this one are that you provide girlfriend work and he provides nothing he can be held to.

The four reasons he won't define it

Ask people why their talking stages never end and the answers are more honest than anything you'll get from him directly. They sort into four.

Convenience. Kwame, 25, on a situation where he wanted a relationship and she avoided naming it: *"I liked her, so I stayed. It hurt, but it also felt convenient."*

Notice he's the one who wanted the label. Convenience isn't a man's problem, it's a position's problem, and whoever's more comfortable is the one who stalls.

Options. Wanjiru, on her three years: *"I wanted to keep my options open without feeling like I was cheating."*

That's the cleanest statement of it available. Without a label there's nothing to be unfaithful to. The undefined status isn't an accident of busy lives. It's doing a job.

The weight. Thabo, 26: *"I didn't want the full weight of taking things to the next step."*

In many African families that weight is specific and it's mostly financial. Defining it means meeting people, being introduced, being asked about intentions, and eventually being measured against a list. Some men stall because they can't currently afford the next step and would rather not say so.

Fear. Amina, 29: *"I was avoiding commitment out of fear."* Zanele, 19: *"I don't want to commit fully and then suffer in the name of love."*

TWO OF THOSE FOUR QUOTES ARE FROM WOMEN

Wanjiru and Zanele were both keeping their own options open. This matters, and not as a scolding. If you go into the conversation in Chapter 4 convinced he is a villain and you are a victim, you will ask it in a tone that produces a fight. Some talking stages stall because both people are hedging. Find out which yours is before you decide what it means.

Which one is yours

You can usually tell, and it changes what you do next.

Convenience looks like a man who is warm, consistent, present, and completely unbothered. Nothing is wrong. Nothing is moving. He would carry on like this for five years.

Options looks like inconsistency that tracks with something. Attentive for ten days, distant for four, back again. His phone is face down.

The weight looks like a man who gets uncomfortable specifically around the future. Money talk, family talk and timeline talk all produce the same deflection, and he's often stressed about work.

Fear looks like someone who moves close then pulls back on his own, with no third party involved, and who has said something at some point about a previous relationship that went badly.

You're not diagnosing him to fix him. You're working out what you're likely to hear in Chapter 4, so it doesn't knock you sideways.

DO THIS NOW

Write down which of the four you think it is, and one piece of evidence for it. Not a feeling. Something he did or said. If you cannot produce a single piece of evidence, that is worth noticing on its own.

The word is doing damage

Every month you call it a stage, you buy him another month.

The word contains the reassurance. It implies motion where there isn't any, and it lets you answer your friends with "we're still talking" in a tone that suggests progress. Stop using it about yourself. Use the word arrangement for a week and watch how differently you feel about the same set of facts.

Next, the thing you've already tried, and the structural reason it can't work.

CHAPTER 2: Why Hinting Never Works

You've already asked. You've asked about six times.

You sent the TikTok about situationships and watched to see if he'd say anything. You mentioned that your friend just got engaged. You said "so what are we even doing" in a laughing voice at 1am, and he said "we're vibing" and you laughed too, because what else were you going to do at that point.

None of those were questions. They were auditions for a question, and he attended all of them.

The five everyone tries

You'll recognise most of these.

The joke. Asked in a tone that lets both of you pretend it wasn't asked. Its whole design is to be deniable, which means his non-answer costs him nothing.

The third party. Your friend's engagement, his cousin's wedding, a celebrity breakup. You're inviting him to volunteer a position on something that isn't about you.

The withdrawal. You go quiet to see if he notices. He notices. He waits. You come back, and the fact that you came back has now answered a question neither of you asked out loud.

The test. You decline something to see what he does. Whatever he does, you'll interpret generously, because you already know what you want it to mean.

The hypothetical. "If we were together, would you..." He answers the hypothetical, warmly and at length, and you leave the conversation feeling reassured and no further forward.

WHY EVERY ONE OF THEM FAILS

A vague question earns a vague answer, and it is not evasion. You asked something that could be answered several ways and he picked the cheapest one. He is not required to guess which answer you were hoping for. As long as the question stays deniable, so does the answer.

What he actually heard

This is the part that stings.

When you hint, he hears that you want more and that you're not going to require it. Both halves land. The first one is flattering. The second one is the reason nothing changes.

A hint communicates your feelings and your tolerance at the same time. He now knows you'd like a title, and he knows you'll stay without one, and those two facts together are an argument for leaving things exactly as they are.

Kwame stayed in his because it was convenient. Convenience is built out of exactly this.

Stop blaming your delivery

Most women in this position conclude they asked badly. Wrong moment, wrong tone, too intense, not casual enough, shouldn't have done it over text.

Your delivery was fine. The problem is that all five of those approaches are designed to protect you from a no. That's what makes them feel safe, and it's exactly what makes them useless, because a question that can't produce a no also can't produce a yes.

THE ESCALATION TRAP

Having read this, the temptation is to go straight at him tonight, annoyed, with months of accumulated evidence. Do not. That is not a question, it is a case, and he will defend himself against it rather than answer it. There is one more thing to do first, and it takes about forty minutes.

What a real question looks like

Three features, and Chapter 4 gives you the wording.

It can be answered yes or no. It asks about now, not about feelings in general. And it is asked once, in a flat ordinary tone, with silence afterwards.

That last part is the hardest and it does most of the work.

Before you ask it, you need to know what's actually sitting between you, because it isn't only affection.

CHAPTER 3: The Number Between You

Two columns. What he's spent on you. What you've spent on him.

Neither of you knows either figure. Both of you are behaving as though you do.

This chapter takes about forty minutes and it's the most uncomfortable part of the book, which is also why it's the part that makes the conversation in Chapter 4 possible.

Why you need both numbers

If you only count what you've given, you'll arrive at the conversation feeling owed, and you'll ask the question with an edge in your voice that turns it into an argument.

If you only count what he's given, you'll arrive feeling indebted, and you'll accept a non-answer because it feels rude to push someone who's been generous.

Both distortions come from missing half the picture. The point of two columns isn't to work out who's ahead. It's to stop the money being a vague pressure and turn it into two figures that sit there and don't argue.

WHAT THE TWO NUMBERS ARE FOR

You are not building a case. You are removing the fog. The reason the question terrifies you is that you cannot tell whether asking makes you demanding or makes you fair, and you cannot tell because you do not know what has actually passed between you.

Reconstructing twelve months

Open your bank app. Go back twelve months.

Column one, what he spent. Dates, transfers to you, airtime, anything he bought. You won't see his side in your app, so reconstruct from your calendar, your photos and your WhatsApp history. Photos are the most reliable record most people have of where they went.

Estimate low. A number you're confident about is worth more than a generous one.

Column two, what you spent. Transfers to him, and search his name and his phone number separately. Money sent to someone else on his behalf. Things you bought that live at his place. Data and airtime. Food you cooked and delivered. Transport to see him, which almost nobody counts and which adds up faster than anything else on the list.

Add the thing nobody measures: time. Not to put a price on it. Just write down roughly how many hours a week this arrangement has taken for as long as this has been going on, because that's the resource you've actually spent most of.

What a date costs now

For context on his column, here's the range of what people say a first date should cost.

The price of a simple lunch. A nice dinner. A night out. Something close to a month's rent.

Different people, different budgets, and very different expectations.

Two people put it in words worth holding onto.

Tendai: *"At least I haven't spent my rent trying to second-guess chemistry."*

Ife: *"I don't want a man performing wealth for me on the first date and then complaining about how expensive women are afterwards."*

That second sentence is the whole of Chapter 6 in one line. Some of the men spending heavily early are running an account in their heads, and you'll hear about it eventually.

DO NOT SHOW HIM THESE COLUMNS

You will want to. It feels like evidence, and evidence feels like power. It is not. Produce a spreadsheet in a relationship conversation and within ten minutes you will be defending a figure from March instead of getting an answer. These two numbers are for your head, not for the table.

The two-column sheet

One page in your notes app.

	What he spent	What I spent
Money (12 months)		
Hours per week		
Largest single thing		
Did either of us ever say what it was for		

That last row is the one that matters, and for almost everybody the answer in both columns is no.

Which is the actual problem. Not the amounts. The fact that a significant sum has moved between two people over months or years and neither has ever named what it was.

YOUR MOVE

1. Forty minutes, twelve months, both columns.
2. Fill the last row honestly, including for yourself.
3. Underneath, write one sentence: what you think he believes that money was for.
4. Then read Chapter 4, tonight if you can.

What this chapter changes

The money has stopped being a feeling. You know roughly what's passed in both directions and you know neither of you ever named it.

You're no longer going into the conversation as someone owed, or as someone indebted. You're going in as someone who wants one piece of information.

That's the right footing, and here's the question.

CHAPTER 4: The Question That Gets an Answer

One question. Once. Then silence.

Not a conversation about where this is going. Not a sit-down. A conversation gives him somewhere to go, and he's had months of practice going there. A question with a yes or no on the end of it has nowhere to go, and that's the entire technique.

Why one question beats a conversation

A conversation about the relationship is a format he knows how to survive. He can be warm in it. He can tell you how much you mean to him, how busy work has been, how he doesn't like labels, how his last relationship ended. All of that is true and none of it is an answer, and you'll come out of it feeling close to him and no clearer.

That's not him being cunning. It's what conversations do. They reward whoever is more comfortable, and in this one that's him.

A single closed question breaks the format. There's a silence after it, and the silence has to be filled by him.

THE MECHANISM OF THE WHOLE BOOK

The power is not in the wording. It is in the silence you leave afterwards. Most women ask a perfectly good question and then rescue him from it within four seconds, because the silence is unbearable. Whoever fills that silence loses it.

Before you ask

Pick your moment badly on purpose. Not a special evening. Not after sex. Not on his birthday. An ordinary Tuesday, in daylight, when nothing else is happening. Special occasions raise the stakes and give him a reason to defer.

Decide your own answer first. If he says no, what do you do. Write it down before you ask. Not to threaten him with. So that you're not deciding your entire future in the ninety seconds after you hear something you didn't want to hear.

Do it in person or on a call. Text gives him unlimited time to compose something that sounds like an answer.

The warm version

SCRIPT 1. For a man you think is stalling out of weight or fear, and for a relationship you'd like to keep.

"I want to ask you something straight, and I'd rather you just tell me the truth than say what you think I want to hear. Are we in a relationship? I'm not asking you to plan our whole life. I just want to know what this is right now."

Then stop. Count to twenty in your head.

Usually provokes: a pause, then either a real answer or one of the four non-answers in Chapter 5. Occasionally relief, because plenty of men have been unsure whether you considered this a relationship either.

The firm version

SCRIPT 2. For a man you think is stalling out of convenience or options, and for when you've already asked in softer ways more than once.

"I've been treating this like a relationship for [time]. I need to know whether that's what it is. Yes or no is fine, but I need an actual answer."

Then stop. Same twenty seconds.

Usually provokes: more resistance than the warm version. Sometimes irritation, occasionally an accusation that you're pressuring him. It's also far more likely to produce a real answer, because it removes the option of a warm deflection.

THE FOUR SECONDS THAT UNDO IT

Almost every woman adds one of these into the silence: "I mean, no pressure." "You don't have to answer now." "Sorry, I know that's a lot." "Forget it, we can talk later." Every one of those is a door out, and he will take it, and you will have to start again in three months. Say the question. Then say nothing at all.

The 48 hours after

However it goes, some rules for the two days that follow.

Don't relitigate it. Whatever he said, that's the answer you work with. Going back the next morning to check whether he really meant it converts your question into anxiety, and it teaches him that answers don't have to be final.

Don't apologise for asking. The apology cancels the question retroactively. If you feel the urge at 11pm, that's normal, and you still don't send it.

Expect a deferral more often than a no. A clean no is rarer than you'd think. What you'll usually get is Chapter 5.

Write down exactly what he said within an hour, in his words. In six weeks you'll remember a warmer version than the one you actually got.

DO THIS NOW

Pick the register. Read it out loud four times until it sounds like you. Write down your own answer to "what do I do if he says no". Then pick the day. Not tonight if tonight is special. Tomorrow, if tomorrow is ordinary.

What this chapter changes

You've got one question, in your register, and you know the silence is the part that matters.

Now the answer that isn't one.

CHAPTER 5: "Let's See How It Goes"

He didn't say no.

He said something warm, slightly vague, and forward-looking. You came away feeling reassured for about a day and a half, and then you realised nothing had actually changed, and you couldn't work out whether you'd been answered or not.

You were answered. This chapter is about recognising it.

The four non-answers

"Let's see how it goes." Also "let it flow", "let's not rush it", "we're getting there". It sounds like patience. It's a request for the current arrangement to continue with no end date, delivered in language that makes objecting look impatient.

"You know how I feel about you." A statement about feelings, offered in place of a statement about status. The two aren't the same and he's substituting one for the other. He may well be very fond of you. That was never the question.

"I'm not ready right now." Honest, and incomplete. Ready is a state that arrives at some point, so the answer needs a second half. Without a date it's the same as the first one in a more sympathetic voice.

"Why are you rushing? Labels don't matter." The only one that's a manoeuvre. It reframes your reasonable question as a character flaw, and if it works you'll spend the next twenty minutes defending yourself. Notice that whoever benefits from no label is the person arguing that labels don't matter.

THE THIRD ANSWER

There are not two possible answers to your question. There are three. Yes, no, and not now. The third one is the one you will almost certainly get, and the mistake is treating it as a delay rather than as an answer. Not now, with no date attached, has the same practical effect as no and costs him nothing.

Why it sounds so reasonable

Because all of it is culturally correct. Everyone says don't rush. Elders say it. Your own mother might say it. There's real wisdom in not forcing something.

The wisdom applies to a relationship that's three months old. You're a year or more in. At that point, "let's not rush" isn't caution, it's preservation of an arrangement, and the reason it works on you is that arguing against it feels like arguing against patience itself.

You're not asking him to marry you. You're asking what to call the thing you're already doing.

The reply

One line. Use it in the same conversation, immediately, not three days later.

SCRIPT 3.

"That's fair. I just need a date. When will you know?"

Short on purpose. It concedes nothing and demands nothing except specificity, which is the one thing a non-answer can't survive.

What happens next sorts itself into three.

He gives you a date. Good. Write it in your calendar, say thank you, change the subject, and hold him to it exactly once when it arrives.

He gives you a vague date. "In a few months." Push once: *"Which month?"* One push, not three.

He won't give you any date. That's your answer, and it's a complete one. A man who will not name a month is not deciding. He's declining while keeping the arrangement.

When the date arrives

Say nothing before it. Not a countdown, not a reminder, not a hint in the week leading up to it.

On the day or shortly after, one message.

"You said you'd know by now. Where are you?"

If he's forgotten entirely, you have learned something more useful than anything he could have said.

THE SECOND EXTENSION

He will sometimes ask for more time, and it will be plausible. Give a first extension if you want to. Do not give a second. A second extension teaches both of you that dates are decorative, and from that point the arrangement is permanent by mutual agreement. One extension is a decision. Two extensions is a lifestyle.

YOUR MOVE

If you have already had a non-answer, send Script 3 today. It works weeks after the original conversation and it does not need a preamble.

What this chapter changes

You can tell an answer from a deferral, you have one line that forces a date, and you know that no date is itself a complete answer.

There's one more thing that can happen, and it's the one nobody warns you about.

CHAPTER 6: When He Asks For It Back

You ask the question. Or you end it. And somewhere in the days that follow, the money arrives.

Not as a feeling. As a figure. What he spent on the hotel in December. The phone. The trips. He has it itemised and he'd like to discuss it.

There are whole threads online where a man complains that the woman he was "talking to" refused to pay back what he spent on her. It isn't a rare event. It's a known move, and if you're going to ask the question you should know what to do if this is what comes back.

Dates are not loans

Start here, because everything else follows from it.

Money spent courting you was spent to obtain your company, and he received your company. That transaction completed at the time. Dinner in March was not a deposit against a relationship in September.

This isn't a technicality. It's what the spending was.

Ife, 30, in Lagos, said it before it happened to her: *"I don't want a man performing wealth for me on the first date and then complaining about how expensive women are afterwards."*

That's the pattern in one sentence. Spending presented as generosity at the time, re-presented as a debt when the hoped-for outcome doesn't arrive. Generosity that converts into an invoice on disappointment was never generosity. It was a bid, and bids can lose.

THE TEST

Ask one question about any amount he names. Was there a repayment date when it was given? If there was, it was a loan and you should settle it. If there was not, it was spending he chose to do, and his disappointment does not turn it into a debt afterwards.

What you actually owe

You owe money lent with a stated understanding that it would come back. If he sent you money for your rent and both of you knew it was a loan, pay it, and pay it whatever else is going on. Being clear-eyed about courtship spending doesn't extend to keeping money you borrowed.

You don't owe dates, meals, hotels, trips, transport, airtime, gifts given as gifts, or anything he bought to spend time with you. That's the cost of pursuing someone, it was voluntary, and it bought exactly what it bought.

The grey area is a large one-off item. A phone, a laptop, rent. If it was called a gift at the time, it's a gift. If you're genuinely unsure, offer it back rather than paying cash for it. Handing over a

phone ends the conversation in a way that a transfer never does, because a transfer invites a second figure.

Two replies

SCRIPT 4, warm register. For when you'd rather it ended civilly, or where there's a genuine loan mixed in.

"I'm not going to argue about what the dates cost, because those were dates and we both enjoyed them. If there's money you actually lent me and expected back, tell me the amount and I'll sort it out."

Usually provokes: either a specific loan figure, which you settle, or a climbdown. Most men asked to separate loans from courtship will quietly drop the courtship part.

SCRIPT 5, firm register. For when there's no real loan and he's pressuring you.

"You chose to spend that money. I didn't ask you for it and there was never any agreement that I'd pay it back. I'm not sending you anything."

Usually provokes: anger, and sometimes a threat to tell people. It also ends the negotiation, which the warm version sometimes doesn't.

DO NOT PAY TO END THE DISCOMFORT

This is the real risk, and it is not about money. Women pay these invoices to make an unbearable conversation stop, and they describe regretting it almost immediately. If you are about to transfer money you do not believe you owe, put the phone down for twenty-four hours first. The discomfort passes. The transfer does not, and it confirms to him that the invoice was legitimate.

If he takes it public

Sometimes it goes to WhatsApp status, to a group chat, to X.

Three things, in order.

Don't respond publicly. Every reply extends the story and gives it a second day. Silence starves it.

Screenshot everything, including anything that amounts to a threat.

Tell two people privately, with the actual numbers, before the story reaches them from him. It'll blow over in a week. Whether that week is pleasant depends mostly on whether your close friends heard it from you first.

If it escalates into threats or the publication of anything private, that's beyond a money argument and beyond this book. Speak to a lawyer, which is an ordinary step rather than a dramatic one.

DO THIS NOW

Go through your two columns from Chapter 3 and mark every item in his column as loan or not-loan. Most will be not-loan. Doing it now, calmly, means you are not deciding it in the middle of an argument later.

What this chapter changes

You know the difference between a loan and a bid, you have two replies, and you know not to pay for silence.

Which leaves the answers themselves.

CHAPTER 7: Both Answers Are Wins

You asked. He answered. Here's what to do with each.

If he says yes

Careful here, because this is where women stop reading and start celebrating.

A yes is a word. What makes it real is what changes in the next two weeks, and you're allowed to say so once, immediately, without spoiling the moment.

SCRIPT 6.

"I'm really glad. Can I say one thing so we're clear. To me being together means we're not seeing other people and I can say you're my boyfriend. Is that how you're thinking about it too?"

It takes thirty seconds and it prevents the specific disaster where you leave the conversation believing you're in a relationship and he leaves believing he agreed to something softer.

Then watch the next two weeks. A real yes shows up as small ordinary changes. He introduces you differently. His phone stops living face down. Plans get made further out than a weekend.

If he says no

This is a win. It won't feel like one tonight.

You asked a question and got an answer, which is more than you had this morning, and you got it at a cost of one conversation rather than another year of guessing. A no also means you can stop auditing his behaviour for evidence, which is a job you've been doing unpaid for a long time.

Amina, 29, said something about the end of an undefined thing that's worth holding onto. The heartbreak feels the same whether it was labelled or not, but the undefined version is harder to process precisely because you weren't official, so you never felt entitled to grieve it properly.

You're entitled. The time you gave was real. That it never had a name doesn't make it smaller.

If he says nothing

The non-answer, no date offered, or a date that came and went.

Treat it as a no. Not out of pride. Because functionally it is one, and the only difference is that this version asks you to keep providing girlfriend work while he retains the option to decide later.

The hardest part is that nothing dramatic has happened, so there's no moment that justifies leaving. You'll have to leave on the basis of an absence, and it'll feel unreasonable. It isn't.

THE REFRAME THIS BOOK EXISTS FOR

You did not fail to get a yes. You succeeded in getting an answer. Those are different projects and only one of them was ever within your control. A clear no in month twenty-five is a better outcome than a warm maybe in month forty.

Leaving without ghosting

If it's ending, end it cleanly. One message, then no debate.

SCRIPT 7.

"I've thought about it and I'm going to step back. I wanted a relationship and that's not what this is, and I'd rather be honest than keep going like nothing's wrong. I'm not angry with you. I hope you're well."

Send it, then mute the chat for a week. Not blocked, muted. Blocking invites a dramatic response and ghosting leaves the loop open in your own head.

There are good free guides online on leaving a talking stage without ghosting, and one is worth reading alongside this chapter.

Expect a message in four to eight weeks that opens warmly and arrives at a request, either for your time or for money. You'll recognise it. You don't have to answer it.

The 90-day rule

Fatou, 26, said her last two connections never got past the talking stage. That's the pattern this rule exists to break.

Ninety days. At three months with a new person you ask the question from Chapter 4. Not a hint. The question.

Ninety days is long enough to know someone and short enough that a no costs you a season rather than a lifetime. Whatever you hear, you've spent three months, not three years, and you can absorb that.

YOUR MOVE

Write "90 days" and today's date in your notes. If you end this one, that is the clock for the next one, and it starts from the first real conversation, not from the first time you thought it might be going somewhere.

What this chapter changes

All three answers have a next step. None of them leaves you where you were this morning.

CONCLUSION: The Question You Ask Tonight

Go back to the two columns.

Months of money, in both directions, and on the last row of that sheet the honest answer in both columns was that neither of you ever said what it was for.

That's the whole problem, restated. It was never really about the title. It was about a significant amount of money, time and girlfriend work moving between two people, with nothing named, and one of them quietly hoping the other would eventually name it.

You're going to name it.

What you now have

You know which of the four reasons he's stalling on and why every hint you tried failed structurally. You've got the two numbers, and the fog around them has cleared. You have the question in two registers, one line that forces a date out of a non-answer, and two replies for the day the money gets presented as a bill.

Seven scripts. None of them require you to be braver than you are, because the only hard part is twenty seconds of silence.

THE WHOLE BOOK IN THREE SENTENCES

A stage is something you pass through, and you have not passed through anything in a long time. The reason you cannot ask is that money has moved and nobody has named it. Name the money, ask once, then say nothing for twenty seconds.

Tonight

Pick a day this week that's ordinary. Not a birthday, not a weekend away, not a night when things are good and you'd rather not disturb them.

Choose the warm script or the firm one and read it out loud four times.

Write down, on paper, what you'll do if the answer is no. Then put it away and don't look at it again until you need it.

That's everything. You'll know by the weekend what you've spent months guessing about, and whichever answer arrives, you'll be further forward than you were when you started this book.

Stop calling it a stage.

The people in this book are composites, but everything they describe is something real women, and men, live through in the talking stage.

The Connection Code